

While-reading activities



Part A Shooting an Elephant

A1 Shooting an Elephant *George Orwell*

In his essay 'Shooting an Elephant', first published in 1936, George Orwell reflects on his life as an official of the British colonial administration in Burma. He explores the conflict of fulfilling his duties while facing the local population's hatred of the colonial government. When he is called to deal with an elephant that has gone out of control, he is torn between his own judgement and the expectations the native population has of him. Read the text and complete the tasks that follow on pp. 16–19.



In Moulmein, in Lower Burma, I was hated by large numbers of people – the only time in my life that I have been important enough for this to happen to me. I was sub-divisional police officer of the town, and in an aimless, petty kind of way anti-European feeling was very bitter.

5 No one had the guts to raise a riot, but if a European woman went through the bazaars alone somebody would probably spit betel juice over her dress. As a police officer I was an obvious target and was baited whenever it seemed safe to do so. When a nimble Burman tripped me up on the football field and the referee (another Burman) 0 looked the other way, the crowd yelled with hideous laughter. This happened more than once. In the end the sneering yellow faces of young men that met me everywhere, the insults hooted after me when I was at a safe distance, got badly on my nerves. The young Buddhist priests were the worst of all. There were several thousands of them 5 in the town and none of them seemed to have anything to do except stand on street corners and jeer at Europeans.

All this was perplexing and upsetting. For at that time I had already made up my mind that imperialism was an evil thing and the sooner I 0 chunked up my job and got out of it the better. Theoretically – and secretly, of course – I was all for the Burmese and all against their oppressors, the British. As for the job I was doing, I hated it more bitterly than I can perhaps make clear. In a job like that you see the dirty work of Empire at close quarters. The wretched prisoners 5 huddling in the stinking cages of the lock-ups, the grey, cowed faces of the long-term convicts, the scarred buttocks of the men who had been flogged with bamboos – all these oppressed me with an intolerable sense of guilt. But I could get nothing into perspective. I was young and ill-educated and I had had to think out my problems in the utter silence that is imposed on every Englishman in the East. I did not even 0 know that the British Empire is dying, still less did I know that it is a great deal better than the younger empires that are going to supplant it. All I knew was that I was stuck between my hatred of the empire I served and my rage against the evil-spirited little beasts who tried to make my job impossible. With one part of my mind I thought of the 5 British Raj as an unbreakable tyranny, as something clamped down, *in saecula saeculorum*, upon the will of prostrate peoples; with another part I thought that the greatest joy in the world would be to drive a bayonet into a Buddhist priest's guts. Feelings like these are the normal by-products of imperialism; ask any Anglo-Indian official, if you can 0 catch him off duty.

One day something happened which in a roundabout way was enlightening. It was a tiny incident in itself, but it gave me a better glimpse than I had had before of the real nature of imperialism – the real motives for which despotic governments act. Early one morning 5 the sub-inspector at a police station the other end of town rang me

¹ **Moulmein** city in Burma (now known as Mawlamyine)

³ **sub-divisional** of a low rank

⁴ **petty** *kleinlich*

⁵ **have the guts to do sth.** (infml) have the courage to do sth.

⁶ **betel** ['bi:tɪl] Asian palm tree (parts of which are chewed for their intoxicating effect)

⁸ **bait sb.** (here) torment sb., tease sb.

nimble agile and skilful

¹⁰ **hideous** ['hɪdiəs] horrible

¹¹ **sneer at sb./sth.** (v) show you have no respect for sb./sth. through a facial expression

¹² **hoot** (v) yell, shout

¹⁶ **jeer at sb.** make fun of sb.

¹⁹ **chuck sth. up** (infml) quit sth.

²³ **at close quarters** from close up

²⁴ **huddle** (v) *kauern*

lock-up (n) prison

cowed [kaʊd] frightened

³¹ **supplant sb./sth.** replace sb./sth.

³⁵ **British Raj** [ra:dʒ] British government of India

clamp down *rigoros durchgreifen*

³⁶ **in saecula saeculorum** (Latin) forever

prostrate (adj, fml) (here) oppressed, defeated

⁴⁴ **despotic** tyrannical



A Burmese bazaar

up on the phone and said that an elephant was ravaging the bazaar. Would I please come and do something about it? I did not know what I could do, but I wanted to see what was happening and I got on to a pony and started out. I took my rifle, an old .44 Winchester and much
 50 too small to kill an elephant, but I thought the noise might be useful *in terrorem*. Various Burmans stopped me on the way and told me about the elephant's doings. It was not, of course, a wild elephant, but a tame one which had gone 'must'. It had been chained up, as tame elephants always are when their attack of 'must' is due, but on the previous night it had broken its chain and escaped. Its mahout, the
 55 only person who could manage it when it was in that state, had set out in pursuit, but had taken the wrong direction and was now twelve hours' journey away, and in the morning the elephant had suddenly reappeared in the town. The Burmese population had no weapons and were quite helpless against it. It had already destroyed somebody's
 60 bamboo hut, killed a cow, and raided some fruit-stalls and devoured the stock; also it had met the municipal rubbish van and, when the driver jumped out and took to his heels, had turned the van over and inflicted violence upon it.

The Burmese sub-inspector and some Indian constables were
 65 waiting for me in the quarter where the elephant had been seen. It was a very poor quarter, a labyrinth of squalid bamboo huts, thatched with palm-leaf, winding all over a steep hillside. I remember that it was a cloudy, stuffy morning at the beginning of the rains. We began questioning the people as to where the elephant had gone and, as
 70 usual, failed to get any definite information. That is invariably the case

⁴⁶ **ravage sth.** ['rævɪdʒ]
destroy sth.

⁵¹ **in terrorem** (Latin)
as a threat

⁵³ **must/musth** (n) (here)
period when male elephants go mad in search of a female elephant to mate with

⁵⁴ **mahout** [mə'haut]
elephant keeper or trainer

⁶¹ **municipal** *kommunal*

⁶⁴ **constable** ['kɒnstəbl]
police officer

⁶⁶ **squalid** in bad condition

thatch sth. with sth.
cover sth. (usu. a roof) with sth.

in the East; a story always sounds clear enough at a distance, but the nearer you get to the scene of events the vaguer it becomes. Some of the people said that the elephant had gone in one direction, some said that he had gone in another, some professed not even to have heard of any elephant. I had almost made up my mind that the whole story was a pack of lies, when we heard yells a little distance away. There was a loud, scandalized cry of 'Go away, child! Go away this instant!' and an old woman with a switch in her hand came round the corner of a hut, violently shooing away a crowd of naked children. Some more women followed, clicking their tongues and exclaiming; evidently there was something that the children ought not to have seen. I rounded the hut and saw a man's dead body sprawling in the mud. He was an Indian, a black Dravidian coolie, almost naked, and he could not have been dead many minutes. The people said that the elephant had come suddenly upon him round the corner of the hut, caught him with its trunk, put its foot on his back, and ground him into the earth. This was the rainy season and the ground was soft, and his face had scored a trench a foot deep and a couple of yards long. He was lying on his belly with arms crucified and head sharply twisted to one side. His face was coated with mud, the eyes wide open, the teeth bared and grinning with an expression of unendurable agony. (Never tell me, by the way, that the dead look peaceful. Most of the corpses I have seen looked devilish.) The friction of the great beast's foot had stripped the skin from his back as neatly as one skins a rabbit. As soon as I saw the dead man I sent an orderly to a friend's house nearby to borrow an elephant rifle. I had already sent back the pony, not wanting it to go mad with fright and throw me if it smelt the elephant.

The orderly came back in a few minutes with a rifle and five cartridges, and meanwhile some Burmans had arrived and told us that the elephant was in the paddy fields below, only a few hundred yards away. As I started forward practically the whole population of the quarter flocked out of the houses and followed me. They had seen the rifle and were all shouting excitedly that I was going to shoot the elephant. They had not shown much interest in the elephant when he was merely ravaging their homes, but it was different now that he was going to be shot. It was a bit of fun to them, as it would be to an English crowd; besides they wanted the meat. It made me vaguely uneasy. I had no intention of shooting the elephant – I had merely sent for the rifle to defend myself if necessary – and it is always unnerving to have a crowd following you. I marched down the hill, looking and feeling a fool, with the rifle over my shoulder and an ever-growing army of people jostling at my heels. At the bottom, when you got away from the huts, there was a metalled road and beyond that a miry waste of paddy fields a thousand yards across, not yet ploughed but soggy from the first rains and dotted with coarse grass. The elephant was

⁷⁸ **switch** (n) rod, stick

⁸² **sprawl** (v) (here) lie stretched out

⁸³ **Dravidian** (adj) belonging to a people from southern India and Sri Lanka
coolie unskilled labourer

⁸⁵ **trunk** (here) an elephant's nose

⁸⁶ **grind sb./sth. (ground – ground)** (hier) jdn./etwas zermahlen

⁸⁷ **score a trench** (here) make a hole

⁹⁰ **bare your teeth** show your teeth

⁹³ **friction** *Reibung*

⁹⁹ **cartridge** *Patrone*

¹⁰⁰ **paddy field** field in which rice is grown

¹⁰² **flock out** come out in crowds

¹⁰⁹ **unnerve sb.** make sb. nervous, frighten sb.

¹¹² **jostle at sb./sth.** crowd around sb./sth.

¹¹³ **metalled road**

Schotterstraße

miry ['maɪəri] muddy or swampy

¹¹⁴ **plough sth.** [plau] etwas pflügen

soggy wet

¹¹⁵ **coarse** [kɔ:s] rough

standing eight yards from the road, his left side towards us. He took not the slightest notice of the crowd's approach. He was tearing up bunches of grass, beating them against his knees to clean them and stuffing them into his mouth.

120 I had halted on the road. As soon as I saw the elephant I knew with perfect certainty that I ought not to shoot him. It is a serious matter to shoot a working elephant – it is comparable to destroying a huge and costly piece of machinery – and obviously one ought not to do it if it can possibly be avoided. And at that distance, peacefully eating, the
125 elephant looked no more dangerous than a cow. I thought then and I think now that his attack of 'must' was already passing off; in which case he would merely wander harmlessly about until the mahout came back and caught him. Moreover, I did not in the least want to shoot him. I decided that I would watch him for a little while to make sure
130 that he did not turn savage again, and then go home.

But at that moment, I glanced round at the crowd that had followed me. It was an immense crowd, two thousand at the least and growing every minute. It blocked the road for a long distance on either side. I looked at the sea of yellow faces above the garish clothes – faces all
135 happy and excited over this bit of fun, all certain that the elephant was going to be shot. They were watching me as they would watch a conjuror about to perform a trick. They did not like me, but with the magical rifle in my hands I was momentarily worth watching. And suddenly I realized that I should have to shoot the elephant after all.
140 The people expected it of me and I had got to do it; I could feel their two thousand wills pressing me forward, irresistibly. And it was at this moment, as I stood there with the rifle in my hands, that I first grasped the hollowness, the futility of the white man's dominion in the East. Here was I, the white man with his gun, standing in front of the
145 unarmed native crowd – seemingly the leading actor of the piece; but in reality I was only an absurd puppet pushed to and fro by the will of those yellow faces behind. I perceived in this moment that when the white man turns tyrant it is his own freedom that he destroys. He becomes a sort of hollow, posing dummy, the conventionalized figure
150 of a sahib. For it is the condition of his rule that he shall spend his life in trying to impress the 'natives', and so in every crisis he has got to do what the 'natives' expect of him. He wears a mask, and his face grows to fit it. I had got to shoot the elephant. I had committed myself to doing it when I sent for the rifle. A sahib has got to act like
155 a sahib; he has got to appear resolute, to know his own mind and do definite things. To come all that way, rifle in hand, with two thousand people marching at my heels, and then to trail feebly away, having done nothing – no, that was impossible. The crowd would laugh at me. And my whole life, every white man's life in the East, was one long
160 struggle not to be laughed at.

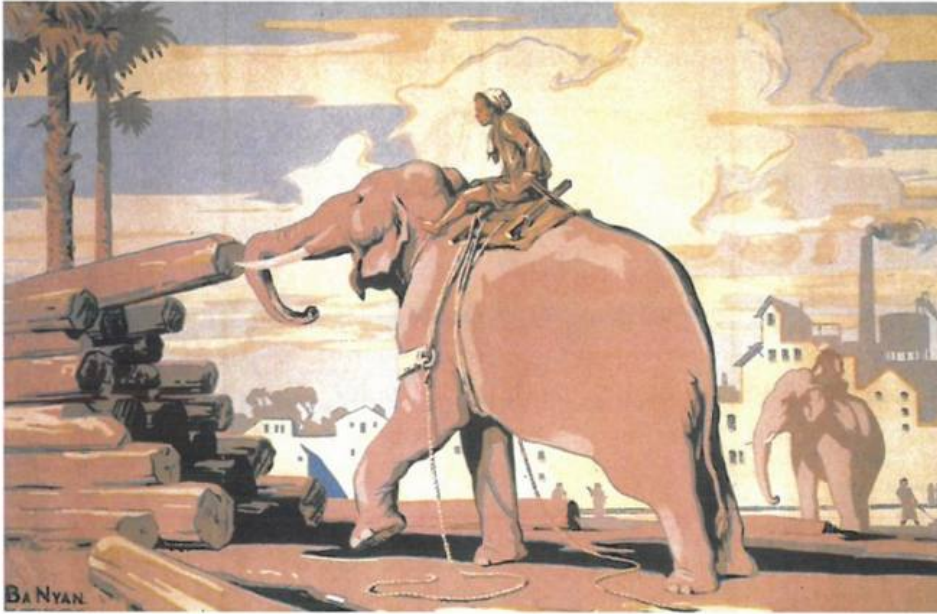
¹³⁴ **garish** strikingly
colourful

¹³⁷ **conjuror** ['kʌndʒərə]
magician

¹⁴³ **grasp sth.** understand
sth.

¹⁵⁰ **sahib** (Urdu) European
man of status

¹⁵⁷ **feeble** weak



But I did not want to shoot the elephant. I watched him beating his bunch of grass against his knees, with that preoccupied grandmotherly air that elephants have. It seemed to me that it would be murder to shoot him. At that age I was not squeamish about killing animals, but I had never shot an elephant and never wanted to. (Somehow it always seems worse to kill a *large* animal.) Besides, there was the beast's owner to be considered. Alive, the elephant was worth at least a hundred pounds; dead, he would only be worth the value of his tusks, five pounds, possibly. But I had got to act quickly. I turned to some experienced-looking Burmans who had been there when we arrived, and asked them how the elephant had been behaving. They all said the same thing: he took no notice of you if you left him alone, but he might charge if you went too close to him.

It was perfectly clear to me what I ought to do. I ought to walk up to within, say, twenty-five yards of the elephant and test his behaviour. If he charged, I could shoot; if he took no notice of me, it would be safe to leave him until the mahout came back. But also I knew that I was going to do no such thing. I was a poor shot with a rifle and the ground was soft mud into which one would sink at every step. If the elephant charged and I missed him, I should have about as much chance as a toad under a steam-roller. But even then I was not thinking particularly of my own skin, only of the watchful yellow faces behind. For at that moment, with the crowd watching me, I was not afraid in the ordinary sense, as I would have been if I had been alone. A white man mustn't be frightened in front of 'natives'; and so, in general, he isn't frightened. The sole thought in my mind was that if anything went wrong those two thousand Burmans would see me pursued, caught, trampled on, and reduced to a grinning corpse like that Indian up the hill. And if that happened it was quite probable that some of them

¹⁶³ **air** (here) appearance, impression given by sb./sth.

¹⁶⁴ **squeamish** zimperlich

¹⁶⁸ **tusk** Stoßzahn

¹⁷³ **charge** (v) attack

¹⁸¹ **toad** Kröte

steam-roller Dampf-walze

190 would laugh. That would never do. There was only one alternative. I
shoved the cartridges into the magazine and lay down on the road to
get a better aim.

The crowd grew very still, and a deep, low, happy sigh, as of people
who see the theatre curtain go up at last, breathed from innumerable
throats. They were going to have their bit of fun after all. The rifle was
a beautiful German thing with cross-hair sights. I did not then know
that in shooting an elephant one should shoot to cut an imaginary bar
running from ear-hole to ear-hole. I ought, therefore, as the elephant
was sideways on, to have aimed straight at his ear-hole; actually
I aimed several inches in front of this, thinking the brain would be
further forward.

When I pulled the trigger I did not hear the bang or feel the kick –
one never does when a shot goes home – but I heard the devilish roar
of glee that went up from the crowd. In that instant, in too short a time,
one would have thought, even for the bullet to get there, a mysterious,
terrible change had come over the elephant. He neither stirred nor fell,
but every line of his body had altered. He looked suddenly stricken,
shrunk, immensely old, as though the frightful impact of the bullet
had paralysed him without knocking him down.

At last, after what seemed a long time – it might have been five
seconds, I dare say – he sagged flabbily to his knees. His mouth
slobbered. An enormous senility seemed to have settled upon him.
One could have imagined him thousands of years old. I fired again
into the same spot. At the second shot he did not collapse but climbed
with desperate slowness to his feet and stood weakly upright, with
legs sagging and head drooping. I fired a third time. That was the shot
that did for him. You could see the agony of it jolt his whole body
and knock the last remnant of strength from his legs. But in falling
he seemed for a moment to rise, for as his hind legs collapsed beneath
him he seemed to tower upwards like a huge rock toppling, his trunk
reaching skywards like a tree. He trumpeted, for the first and only
time. And then down he came, his belly towards me, with a crash that
seemed to shake the ground even where I lay.

I got up. The Burmans were already racing past me across the mud.
It was obvious that the elephant would never rise again, but he was
not dead. He was breathing very rhythmically with long rattling gasps,
his great mound of a side painfully rising and falling. His mouth was
wide open. I could see far down into caverns of pale pink throat. I
waited a long time for him to die, but his breathing did not weaken.
Finally, I fired my two remaining shots into the spot where I thought
his heart must be. The thick blood welled out of him like red velvet,
but still he did not die. His body did not even jerk when the shots hit
him, the tortured breathing continued without a pause. He was dying,
very slowly and in great agony, but in some world remote from me

- 191 **shove sth./sb.**
[ʃʌv] push sth./sb.
196 **cross-hair sight**
Fadenkreuzvisier
197 **bar (n)** (here) line
204 **glee** cheerfulness
206 **stir (v)** move
207 **alter** ['ɔ:lɪə] (v) change
211 **flabby** limp, slack
212 **slobber** *sabbern*
216 **droop (v)** hang down
217 **jolt sb./sth.** *etwas/*
jdn. erschüttern
218 **remnant** remains
226 **rattle (v)** *rasseln*
gasp (n) deep breath
227 **mound** heap
228 **cavern** ['kævən] *Höhle*
231 **velvet** type of soft
cloth
232 **jerk (v)** move
suddenly

5 where not even a bullet could damage him further. I felt I had got to put an end to that dreadful noise. It seemed dreadful to see the great beast lying there, powerless to move and yet powerless to die, and not even to be able to finish him. I sent back for my small rifle and poured shot after shot into his heart, and down his throat. They seemed to
 0 make no impression. The tortured gasps continued as steadily as the ticking of a clock.

In the end I could not stand it any longer and went away. I heard later that it took him half an hour to die. Burmans were bringing dahs and baskets even before I left, and I was told they had stripped his
 5 body almost to the bones by the afternoon.

Afterwards, of course, there were endless discussions about the shooting of the elephant. The owner was furious, but he was only an Indian and could do nothing. Besides, legally I had done the right thing, for a mad elephant has to be killed, like a mad dog, if its owner
 0 fails to control it. Among the Europeans opinion was divided. The older men said I was right, the younger men said it was a damn shame to shoot an elephant for killing a coolie, because the elephant was worth more than any damn Coringhee coolie. And afterwards I was very glad that the coolie had been killed; it put me legally in the right and it gave
 5 me a sufficient pretext for shooting the elephant. I often wondered whether any of the others grasped that I had done it solely to avoid looking a fool.

From: Orwell, Shooting an Elephant and Other Essays, London: Penguin, 2003, pp. 31–40.

²⁴³ **dah** (Burmese) knife

²⁵³ **Coringhee** ['kɔrɪŋgi:]
people from southern
India

²⁵⁵ **pretext** excuse



Info George Orwell

Eric Arthur Blair was born in British India on 25 June 1903. He went to school in England before returning to the colony as an imperial policeman in Burma. Being dissatisfied with Britain's colonial rule, he resigned and became a writer, using the pseudonym George Orwell for his literary work. Later, he joined the Spanish Republicans in their struggle against Franco's regime. In his books, Orwell reflects on his personal experience as well as his political views. His work includes colonial literature like his first novel, *Burmese Days*, and the famous works *Animal Farm* and *1984*, in which he anticipated many features of a modern dictatorship. Suffering from tuberculosis, Orwell died on 21 January 1950, three months after his wedding.

**A2 Working for the Empire**

Look back at lines 1–130 of the essay 'Shooting and Elephant' and complete tasks 1–6.

Comprehension

1 Complete the sentences below by ticking the correct answer. Only one option is correct.

a Orwell works as a/an ...

- A** referee.
- B** football player.
- C** imperial police officer.
- D** young Buddhist priest in Moulmein, Burma.

b The Burmese ...

- A** help Orwell during a football match.
- B** work hard to please their British masters.
- C** start a riot against the British colonial government.
- D** disrespect and tease Europeans whenever possible.

c In Orwell's view, the British colonial administration ...

- A** is a dictatorship oppressing its population.
- B** should punish the Burmese for their cheeky behaviour.
- C** is flawed but still better than most other forms of government.
- D** contributes to the development of the country and helps people escape poverty.

d One morning, Orwell is called to ...

- A buy an elephant.
- B investigate a murder.
- C stop a riot at a local bazaar.
- D stop an elephant which has gone wild.

e The huge animal has already ...

- A seriously injured the driver of a rubbish van.
- B killed its mahout and turned over a rubbish van.
- C eaten a cow and destroyed somebody's bamboo hut.
- D destroyed a hut, raided food stalls and destroyed a municipal van.

f When Orwell is almost certain that the whole story has been made up, he ...

- A finds the elephant chasing a crowd of naked children.
- B comes across the body of a man killed by the elephant.
- C witnesses how the elephant kills a black Dravidian coolie.
- D sees an old woman attacking a man with a switch in her hand.

g When Orwell eventually finds the elephant on a paddy field, ...

- A the animal is still out of control and he shoots it right away.
- B there is a fight between the crowd of Burmese spectators and the police.
- C he decides that the elephant no longer poses a threat and returns home.
- D the elephant appears calm and he feels that it is unnecessary to shoot it.

Analysis

- 2 Illustrate the elephant's behaviour and Orwell's reaction to it.
- 3 Look back at II. 1–40. Examine Orwell's relationship with the local Burmese population.
- 4 Point out Orwell's perception of Britain's colonial rule in Burma as well as his perception of his job.

Beyond the text

- 5 **Writing** Imagine you are Orwell, one day before the incident. Write a letter to a friend in which you complain about the way the British dominate the local Burmese population.
- 6 **Speaking** Work in pairs. Act out a dialogue between Orwell and a man from the Burmese village in which they discuss whether the elephant should be shot.



British forces entering Mandalay, Burma, in 1885. Burma gained independence from the UK in 1948.

A3 The pressure to act

Look back at the second part of Orwell's essay 'Shooting an Elephant' (lines 131–257) and complete tasks 1–5.

Comprehension

1 Complete the sentences below using information from the text.

A When Orwell decides to go home without shooting the elephant, he looks back and is surprised to see that _____.

B The villagers urge him to _____.

C In this situation, he understands that, as a European in Burma, he has to _____.

D Orwell does not want to shoot the elephant because _____.

E He fears that the elephant might _____.

F More importantly, he cannot bear the thought that the Burmese _____.

G When Orwell shoots at the elephant, he is shocked that the huge animal _____.

H Even after being hit by multiple bullets, it takes _____ for the elephant to die.

I The local citizens rush towards the animal and _____.

J When the elephant has died, people _____.

Analysis

- 2 Use the following quote as a starting point to analyse the relationship between the colonizers and the colonized in Orwell's essay.

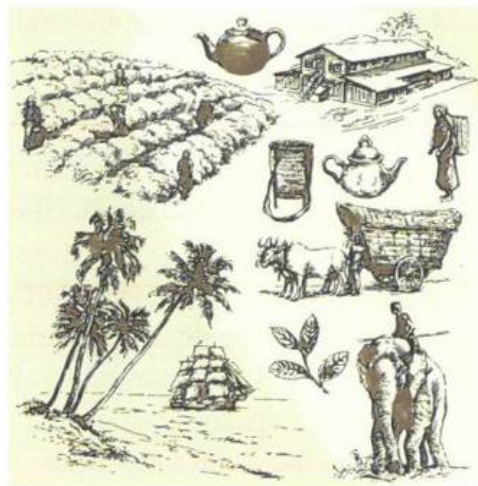
'I perceived in this moment that when the white man turns tyrant it is his own freedom that he destroys.' (ll. 147–148)

- 3 In groups of 3 to 5 students, discuss the ways in which Orwell criticizes the British Empire in his essay.

Beyond the text

4 YOU CHOOSE:

- a **Writing** Imagine you are Orwell. Write his diary entry one week after shooting the elephant.
OR
b **Writing** Imagine you are the elephant's owner. Write an interior monologue in which you reflect on the incident, the consequences this has had for you, and whether this has changed how you feel about being a subject of the British Empire.
- 5 Examine why the elephant has often been interpreted as a metaphor for the British Empire.



A4 Reflecting on colonialism

- 1 a Describe the cartoon below.



- b Explain the message of the cartoon. Assess how it expresses disapproval of Britain's colonial past.